

CityUniversity in Canada

CPC 527: Group Counselling Psychology

School of Health and Social Sciences

Credits: 3

Grading Type: Decimal

Faculty Information

Kelsey Murrin

Email: murrinkelsey@cityu.edu

For additional information, see the "Meet your Instructor" page in the course.

Course Catalog Description

This course provides an experiential introduction to group processing theory including exposure to a variety of therapeutic groups designed to provide support for deeper exploration of self and relationship to others. Students will participate both as facilitators and members of a variety of therapeutic groups. A number of topics will be explored throughout the course including: 1) the history of group therapy; 2) the benefits and challenges of therapeutic groups; and 3) the influences of culture, class, gender, sexuality, and age on group dynamics.

Throughout CityU's Master of Counselling Program, students are encouraged to film themselves and review their

counselling skills when working in dyads, triads or groups. Note that the consent of all participants involved must be acquired before any filming may proceed.

Consideration of Social Justice Issues

City University in Canada is committed to social justice, access, and inclusion. Throughout their studies in the Master of Counselling Program, students are invited to reflect on a range of social justice questions as follows:

- How does our own experience of privilege impact our ability to critically evaluate counselling theories and the provision of counselling services within the counselling field?
- What is the experience of racialized and othered individuals within counselling, e.g., are clients able to see themselves represented within their counsellor, or the counselling experience? Are indigenous healing practices acknowledged?
- Why do the majority of counselling theories represent the academic and research views of predominantly white, middle-class, European, male perspective? Which counselling theories break away from this dominant perspective, and how do they contribute to our overall understanding of working with cultures and identities that differ from our own?

Territorial Acknowledgement & Statement of Inclusion

City University in Canada (CityU) acknowledges and respects that we are on the traditional territories of First Nations, Metis, and Inuit Peoples. Each of our campuses resides on a different territory, each with their own distinct languages, culture, and traditions. In the spirit of

reconciliation and in respect of the diversity among nations, we would like to acknowledge the territories for each of our campuses.

We acknowledge that our Vancouver, British Columbia campus is located on the unceded and traditional territory of the Coast Salish Nations of xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), səɫílwətaʔɫ (Tsleil-Waututh), and Skwxwú7mesh (Squamish) Peoples.

We acknowledge that our Southern Vancouver Island campus is located on the traditional and unceded territory of the Coast Salish Peoples of the Esquimalt, Songhees, and W̱SÁNEĆ Nations.

The lands that we at CityU are on hold the history and cultural traditions of many Indigenous Peoples. We recognize that Indigenous traditions, knowledge, and languages have been deeply damaged by the ongoing colonization of and biases against Indigenous Peoples. We acknowledge these territories with respect to their heritage and communities. With this acknowledgment, we are committed to begin building and maintaining respectful relationships with local Indigenous communities.

CityU honours human diversity in all its forms and is committed to the principle of universal human dignity. We further acknowledge that our learning community is greatly enriched through the voices and perspectives of staff, faculty, and students from all intersections of society including LGBTQ+, BIPOC and diversely-abled communities.

Course Resources

Required and recommended resources to complete coursework and assignments are found on the course [Reading List](#). The reading list can be found in the top navigation menu in Brightspace as well as from the library homepage.

Note: Required resources that must be purchased by the student are tagged “Purchase from a vendor of your choosing.” Required resources with a direct link, “Available through CityU Library”, are available at no cost to students.

Students in Canada will see required resources they need to purchase tagged “Purchase from the Canadian Bookstore.” Students outside the U.S. and Canada should contact their advisor or textbook coordinator for additional information.

Program Learning Outcomes

The content of this course aligns with the following Learning Outcomes:

PO 1 Counselling Skills: Apply sound essential Counselling skills derived from a credible knowledge base that encompasses diverse theoretical perspectives:

PO 7 Ethical Practice: Recognize and apply professional ethical standards including clear and appropriate relationships with clients, colleagues, and the community.

1.1 Therapeutic Conversations: Facilitate therapeutic conversations that clarify the presenting problem and demonstrate empathy, active listening, attunement, and rapport-building skills.

1.2 Diagnosis & Treatment: Develop informed diagnoses and appropriate, culturally-relevant treatment and risk mitigation plans.

1.3 Application: Synthesize and apply relevant counselling theories and frameworks in a culturally-competent manner when treating clients.

1.4 Client-Centered Care: Provide compassionate, client-centered care appropriate for the age, history, race/ethnicity, religion, culture, sexual orientation, intersectionality, social location and other unique contexts of the client(s).

1.5 Professional Boundaries: Establish and maintain professional boundaries.

7.1 Law & Policy: Analyze and apply local, provincial, and federal laws, policies, and procedures governing the counselling profession.

7.2 Ethical Relationships: Build and maintain ethical relationships that respect professional boundaries, sociocultural contexts, and power differentials.

7.3 Decision Making: Apply decision making models and sound judgement when navigating ethical dilemmas.

Course Assignments and Grading

The grades earned for the course will be derived using CityU's decimal grading system, based on the following:

Overview of Required Assignments

Overview of Required Assignments	% of Final Grade
Group Therapy Reflection Paper	25%
Peer-Review Group Assignment	10%
TOTAL	100%

<i>Overview of Required Assignments</i>	<i>% of Final Grade</i>
Group Facilitation Presentation/Project	40%
Collaboration & Participation	25%
TOTAL	100%

Course Assignment Details

Group Therapy Reflection Paper (25%).

Students will write a reflection paper critiquing their facilitation performance. This 5 - 6 -page, double-spaced paper will include: 1) observations about group dynamics and power dynamics with facilitators; 2) an assessment of members' roles within the group; 3) an analysis of successful and unsuccessful interventions; and 4) ways that co-facilitators can integrate feedback into their group leadership style.

This paper must include a minimum of five peer-reviewed sources from the past 5 years supporting students' reflections. APA formatting and citations are mandatory as the failure to cite sources appropriately constitutes plagiarism.

Group Therapy Reflection Paper		
<i>Grading Criteria</i>	<i>Grade Points</i>	<i>% of Grade</i>
Organization and Coherence	10 Points	10%
Evidence and Support	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points	20%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Professional Ethics	20 Points	20%
Cultural Competence	20 Points	20%
Self-reflection	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Peer-Review Group Report (10%)

Peer review is a core academic activity in which colleagues support one another's professional development by offering feedback on each other's scholarly work. Students will provide feedback using a structured template to their assigned facilitation group.

Peer-Review Group Report

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Organization and Coherence	10 Points	10%
Evidence and Support	20 Points	20%
Analysis and use of Course Concepts	20 Points	20%
Evaluating Information	20 Points	20%
Self-reflection	20 Points	20%
APA (written) or participation (oral)	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Group Facilitation Presentation/Project (40%)

For the written component of this assignment, students will break into dyads, select their own therapeutic issue, and develop a treatment plan to be implemented in the single session group counselling scenario they will facilitate. This plan should be 6 – 8 pages in length, double-spaced using APA formatting and a minimum of five scholarly sources. This assignment will include: 1) background on the

presenting issue and an explanation of why it is appropriate for group counselling; 2) a clear rationale for the modality being used; 3) inclusion and exclusion criteria for group membership; and 4) relevant diversity and ethics issues. The treatment plan should also include a summary sheet outlining: 1) group goals; 2) learning outcomes for the session; and 3) contingency plans for resolving group challenges.

For the experiential component of this assignment, students will conduct a 90-minute co-facilitated group session based on the written group treatment plan.

Group Facilitation Presentation/Project

Grading Criteria	Grade Points	% of Grade
Case Conceptualization /Treatment Analysis and use of Course Concepts	10 Points	10%
Professional Ethics	20 Points	20%
Cultural Competence	20 Points	20%
Oral Presentation	20 Points	20%
Therapeutic Conversations	10 Points	10%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Collaboration & Participation (25%).

The in-person class portion of this course depends heavily on small and large group activities and discussion designed to foster skill-based competencies necessary for clinical work in a group setting. For these activities to be meaningful, the student must be prepared, having done prior reading and be willing to engage with group members during group discussions and practice activities to help to foster a

collaborative learning environment. Student are asked to actively seek to help promote safer spaces within the class by recognizing and respecting differences within and between classmates and the instructor, as well as each participant's willingness to observe strict confidentiality is another important aspect of a collaborative approach to learning.

Students will be asked to complete a participation self-assessment (template will be provided) to reflect on their own experience of engagement, participation and collaboration.

Collaboration & Participation

<i>Grading Criteria</i>	<i>Grade Points</i>	<i>% of Grade</i>
Communication	20 Points	20%
Engagement & Attendance	20 Points	20%
Empathy & Compassion	20 Points	20%
Self- Awareness	20 Points	20%
Self- Regulation	20 Points	20%
TOTAL	100 Points	100%

Course Policies

Late Assignments

Graduate students are expected to submit all assignments by the due dates stated in the syllabus. A late assignment is one that is submitted after the due date and time or after any extension has expired.

If circumstances prevent a student from meeting the due date, students should contact the instructor and request an extension at least 48 hours prior to the date the assignment is due. Emergency situations will be considered on a case-by-case basis. Being busy, pressured with outside work, or having competing academic commitments are not usually considered valid reasons to receive extensions.

A student who receives an extension in advance of the due date and abides by the agreement with the instructor is not subject to late penalties. The guideline for late penalties is a deduction of one point per day from the overall grade for the first 10 days and 5 points per day after 10 days. Instructors may vary these guidelines in response to the specific conditions and requirements of each course. In the absence of an alternative announced by the Instructor the default policy is the general guideline cited above. Assignments may be re-written only with the express consent of the Instructor and under exceptional circumstances.

Participation

All MC courses encourage active engagement in discussion, dialogue, role plays and similar exercises in order to receive the maximum educational benefits. Participation includes constructive criticism and the negotiation of different perspectives and ideas. Recognizing that there are many forms of participation a range of forms and styles are welcomed. Active engagement means being attentive. Similarly, it is recognized that there are situations in which learning to hold one's counselor to not participate verbally are valuable learning experiences.

Consistent attendance and a willingness to be actively involved in classroom discussions, small group activities, and at times classroom presentations or role plays assists in creating a vibrant learning community.

Many MC courses include a participation component and, in some cases, assignments specify that participation will be graded. In such cases the criteria for participation will be made known along with the requirements for grade achievement.

Professional Writing

Assignments require error-free writing that uses standard English conventions and logical flow of organization to address topics clearly, completely, and concisely. CityU requires the use of APA style.

University Policies

Students are responsible for understanding and adhering to all of CityU's academic policies. The most current versions of these policies can be found in the [University Catalog](#) that is linked from the CityU Web site.

Non-Discrimination & Prohibition of Sexual Harassment

City University of Seattle, its staff and its faculty are deeply committed to supporting our students. We value equity, diversity, and inclusion as a way of life as well as for the educational opportunities it provides. CityU will not tolerate any form of discrimination based on race, color, ethnicity, sexual orientation, gender identification, socioeconomic status, or religious values. Any student who has experienced discrimination based on the above criteria is encouraged to report this to the University. Students may report an experience of discrimination to their course instructor. If they do not feel safe reporting to their instructor,

students may report an experience of discrimination directly to the university Provost or the Vice President of Student Affairs.

CityU adheres to all federal, state, and local civil rights laws prohibiting discrimination in employment and education. The University is committed to ensuring that the education environment is bounded by standards of mutual respect and safety and is free from discriminatory practices.

In Canada, in compliance with the British Columbia Human Rights Code, the Alberta Human Rights Act, WorksafeBC, and the Workers' Compensation Board of Alberta, the University believes that its environment should at all times be supportive and respectful of the dignity and self-esteem of individuals. Discrimination, harassment and bullying conduct, whether through person-to-person behaviour or via electronic communications such as email or social media is not acceptable and will not be tolerated. As an educational institution, it is our responsibility to cultivate an environment of excellence, equity, mutual respect and to recognize the value and potential of every individual. The University will take all necessary steps to meet or exceed the requirements of the law to prevent discrimination, harassment and bullying. Information on the prevention of discrimination, harassment and bullying can be found at [Canada's Respectful Workplace Policy](#).

Religious Accommodations

CityU has a policy for accommodation of student absences or significant hardship due to reasons of faith or conscience, or for organized religious activities. The University's policy, including more information about how to request an accommodation, is available in the University Catalog and on the my.cityu.edu student portal. Accommodations must be requested by the 20% mark of this course (e.g. day 14 of

a ten-week course, day 7 of a 5-week course) using the Religious Accommodations Request Form found on the student dashboard in the my.cityu.edu student portal.

Academic Integrity Academic integrity in students requires the pursuit of scholarly activity that is free from fraud, deception and unauthorized collaboration with other individuals. Students are responsible for understanding CityU's policy on academic integrity and adhering to its standards in meeting all course requirements. A complete copy of this policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under Student Rights and Responsibilities on the page titled Academic Integrity Policy.

Attendance

Students taking courses in any format at the University are expected to be diligent in their studies and attend class regularly. Regular class attendance/contact is important in achieving learning outcomes in the course and correlates in many cases with participation. As such it may be a valid consideration in determining the final grade. At the beginning of each course, the instructor will inform students of the relevance of class attendance/contact to the final grade.

Attendance in this class is vital to learning the required course material and demonstrates professionalism and respect for fellow students and the instructor. All students are required to attend every class for the full duration of the class. Arriving late or leaving early will constitute an unexcused absence. It is expected that students who will not be attending or who will be arriving late notify the instructor before class starts.

Excused absences are limited to ILLNESS OR EMERGENCY. Absences related to illness may require

verification from a medical doctor. All other absences will be considered unexcused.

In the event of inclement weather, students will be notified by a CityU representative and / or faculty of site closures. As student and faculty safety is a priority, students who feel that driving conditions are unsafe will be permitted an excused absence without penalty. Students are responsible for notifying the instructor before class starts that they will not be attending class due to inclement weather.

Students with more than 2 unexcused absences will be directed to meet with the local Program Director to discuss continued participation in the course. 3% of students' overall course grade will be deducted for each unexcused absence.

A complete copy of CityU's policy can be found in the [University Catalog](#) under Student Rights and Responsibilities on the page titled Attendance.

Final Assignment Due Date

Final assignments for each class at CityU must be due on or before the final date of the course as indicated in the university's course information system. Due dates that extend beyond the final date of the course may negatively impact tuition funding for students.

Support Services

Disability Services Accommodations Statement

Students with a need for academic accommodation for disability, pregnancy, or religious reasons are encouraged to contact the Student Accommodation Office to discuss accommodation requests and eligibility requirements. Please contact the Student Accommodation Services at

accommodations@cityu.edu or 206.239.4751 or visit the [accommodations support page](#) in the my.cityu.edu portal or in the Start Your Course Here module in your course under Support Services.

Confidentiality will be observed in all inquiries. Once approved, information about academic accommodations will be shared with course instructors.

Mental Health and Wellness Resources

In this complex and evolving world, your mental health matters. Discover the different resources available to support your well-being.

Empower Me is a confidential mental health and wellness service, is available 24/7, 365 days a year. This service is complimentary for all CityU students in Canada. Visit [Empower Me](#) for more information.

For students attending in Canada but temporarily located outside of Canada, Empower Me is available through the Dialogue mobile app or platform (maximum of 90 days). Access [Dialogue](#) to create your account and get started.

CityU's Counselling Clinics offer free counselling services in a convenient format. To learn more, visit the [Counselling Clinics](#) web page.

Healthmind Clinic is an integral part of City University in Canada. A not-for-profit institution with a rich legacy of training exceptional counsellors for over 25 years, Healthmind offers a safe and inclusive environment to access counselling support and innovative clinical training, supervision and education. Visit [Healthmind Clinic](#) for more information.

Here2Talk is a valuable resource for students in British Columbia. A virtual counselling service, Here2Talk provides free mental health support to students via an app, over the phone, or through online chat. Experienced professionals provide support 24/7 and no appointment is needed. Visit [Here2Talk](#) for more information.

For **Federal and Provincial Government support services**, visit the [Other Mental Health Resources](#) web page.

Library Services

CityU librarians are available to help students find the resources and information they need to succeed in this course. Contact a CityU librarian through the [Ask a Librarian](#) service, or access [library resources and services online](#), 24 hours a day, seven days a week.

Online Tutoring

CityU students have access to free online tutoring offered through Brainfuse, including writing support, from certified tutors 24 hours a day, seven days a week. For more information visit the [Brainfuse](#) page on the [my.cityu.edu](#) portal.

Course Schedule

Course Schedule

Week	Modules	Topics	Readings
4/2/26	MODULE 1	Intro to Group Work	Corey Ch. 1 & 2 Yalom Ch. 1

Week	Modules	Topics	Readings
4/9/26	MODU LE 2	Introduction to Group Work Pt. 2	Corey Ch. 3 & 4 Yalom Ch. 2
4/16/26	MODU LE 3	Group Stages: Initial Stages	Corey Ch.5 & 6 Yalom Ch. 3
4/23/26	MODU LE 4	Group Stages: Transition	Corey Ch. 7 Yalom Ch. 4 & 5
4/30/26	MODU LE 5	Group Stages: Working	Corey Ch. 8 Yalom Ch. 6 & 7
5/7/26	MODU LE 6	Presentations	Yalom Ch. 8 & 9
5/14/26	MODU LE 7	Presentations	Yalom Ch. 10 & 11
5/21/26	READI NG WEEK	READING WEEK	READING WEEK
5/28/26	MODU LE 8	Presentations	Yalom Ch. 12 & 13
6/4/26	MODU LE 9	Group Stages: Final	Corey Ch. 9 See Brightspace for Assigned Readings
6/11/26	MODU LE 10	Groups in Diverse Settings	Corey Ch. 10 & 11 Yalom Ch. 14 & 15
6/18/26	MODU LE 11	Effective Closings	See Brightspace for Assigned Readings

Reminder to submit End of Course Evaluations.

Rubrics

Please see Brightspace for rubrics associated with each assignment.

Sensitive Content Notice

Because the counselling profession is designed to explore the inner life of individuals, certain content discussed in CityU's Master of Counselling courses may be emotionally activating for students. The university's goal is to empower students to practice active self-care throughout their time in the program. Active self-care is an ethical responsibility for those in self-regulating professions and assists clinicians in successfully meeting clients in spaces where emotionally sensitive content is present. Similarly, in the Master of Counselling program, an ethic of care for the self is a critical consideration.

Emotionally sensitive content involves a wide variety of topics including, but not limited to, abuse, assault, neglect, self-harm, identity, sexuality, appearance, misogyny, classism, racialized issues, colonization, religious practices, trauma, grieving, ageism, caregiving, and physical or mental health. Students are encouraged to carefully attend to their emotional wellbeing when reading, listening to, viewing, or participating in course activities involving sensitive content.

It is important to note that exploring sensitive content is an inherent part of the counselling profession. However, the complexity of human experience means students' personal histories may become activated to the point that effective

learning is no longer feasible. In such cases, students are encouraged to prioritize balancing their emotional wellbeing with their professional growth. This may be done through timely self-reflection and communication with instructors and/or peers about the self-regulation strategies students will implement while engaging sensitive content.

As part of their professional growth, students are also encouraged to pursue personal counselling related to sensitive content explored in the program. Personal counselling deepens students' learning and provides insight into their future clients' experiences of the therapeutic process. Additional resources available to students include the Empower Me Program, Self-Care folders in Brightspace, and local campus wellness initiatives.

Master of Counselling's Professional Code

In addition to City University's general student code of conduct located in the Registrar's City U Calendar, counselling students are further expected to conduct themselves in a manner that is consistent with the core values of the profession they are entering. Students will be encouraged to adopt the following behaviours and are accountable to their peers, faculty, and CityU to sincerely undertake the development of these hallmarks of maturity:

1. Respect the dignity of classmates, faculty, and administrators without prejudice in all forms of behaviour and communication in matters of race, religion, skin colour, ethnicity, gender, orientation, physical presentation, age, ancestry or birthplace. This includes, but is not limited to, standing up against and/or reporting behaviours such as bullying, scapegoating, gossip, slander etc.

2. Maintain a positive approach to managing course-related, administrative, or relationship challenges in line with the core values of the profession. This includes, but is not limited to, directly approaching specific individuals regarding concerns of note and attempting to collaborate and independently problem-solve prior to involving faculty or administrators in the matter. Students who feel unable to independently resolve the issue should seek the support of cohort representatives, faculty, or staff.
3. Demonstrate exemplary personal conduct consistent with the values of the profession including integrity, accountability, reflexivity, generosity, compassion, inclusiveness, honesty, courage, maturity, thoughtfulness, good judgment, patience, and fairness. Demonstrate a commitment to modelling the standards and ethics of the counselling profession in all aspects of personal conduct in both the university and community at large.
4. Access City University's campuses or resources ONLY with approval from an authorized representative of the university.
5. Recognize that students with formal academic accommodations are expected to meet the same academic standards as their peers with the help of additional supports and reasonable, penalty free extensions.
6. Recognize that consistent face-to-face and online class attendance is a basic, non-negotiable requirement of the program and that the program's attendance policies will be enforced without exception. Students who are absent for any reason are required to make up all instructional hours and assignments at the discretion of the instructor.
7. Ensure that all requests for assignment extensions (with and without accommodations) are submitted to faculty a minimum of 48 hours in advance of the assignment due date. Extensions may not be granted after assignment due dates have passed.
8. Respect and behave in accordance with the appropriate professional boundaries inherent in faculty, administrative, and evaluative roles.
9. As an ambassador for the City University program, conduct themselves in a manner that strengthens the

reputation of the profession, one's peers, and the program.

10. Actively develop and practice the core counselling skills of attunement, presence, and empathy in all program-related interpersonal interactions.
11. Respond to feedback from faculty and administrators in ways that facilitate personal growth, preserve our collaborative learning environment, and reflect the standards of the counselling profession.
12. Balance enthusiastic contributions to classroom discussion with ensuring there is sufficient space for all voices to be heard. This involves actively staying aware of the dynamics of class discussions and actively encouraging everyone's participation.
13. Commit to active course participation that contributes to one's own and others learning.
14. Embrace both positive and challenging academic learning opportunities and consider how these experiences can be applied in the service of personal and professional growth.